

draft-analysis

WC2026 Fantasy Draft — Best Candidates by Position

Scoring: Goals = 1pt, Assists = 1pt, Yellow Cards = 1pt, Red Cards = 1pt, Clean Sheets = 1pt (GK only), Coach Winner = 10pt. Constraint: Max 1 player per country. Historical pts from WC2022/WC2014 database events (clean sheets excluded — no lineup data available).

Forwards (pick 5)

Rank	Player	Country	WC Hist.	G	A	YC	RC	Pts	2025-26 Club Form / Notes
1	Kylian Mbappe	FRA	WC22	8	2	0	0	10	Real Madrid. 39+ goals/season for 6 years. Golden Boot fav (6/1)
2	Erling Haaland	NOR	—	—	—	—	—	NEW	Man City. 55 int'l goals in 49 caps. 16 qualifying goals (2x any European). Penalty taker
3	Harry Kane	ENG	WC22	2	3	0	0	5	Bayern. 78 career int'l goals. FOX #2 overall
4	Viktor Gyokeres	SWE	—	—	—	—	—	NEW	Arsenal. 14G 1A 5YC in PL. Physical = 5 yellows (bonus!). Scored playoff winner vs Poland
5	Lamine Yamal	ESP	—	—	—	—	—	NEW	Barcelona. 24G 17A all comps. LaLiga POTS. Age 18 — monitor fitness
6	Julian Alvarez	ARG	WC22	4	0	0	0	4	Golden Boot dark horse (33/1). Lethal duo with Lautaro
7	Alexander Isak	SWE	—	—	—	—	—	NEW	Liverpool. Injury-disrupted season but world-class finisher (54G in 86 PL apps at Newcastle)
8	Mohamed Salah	EGY	—	—	—	—	—	NEW	Liverpool. Egypt's talisman. First WC since 2018
9	Mikel Oyarzabal	ESP	—	—	—	—	—	NEW	Top fantasy-rated FWD (8.1). Pen taker. 24G in 52 Spain apps. Easy group
10	Vinicius Junior	BRA	WC22	1	2	0	0	3	Real Madrid. FOX #3 overall
11	Raphinha	BRA	—	—	—	—	—	NEW	Barcelona. 34G + 22A this season. Brazil's biggest goal threat
12	Patrik Schick	CZE	—	—	—	—	—	NEW	Leverkusen. 16G 3A in Bundesliga. Hat-trick + 9G in last 7. On fire
13	Goncalo Ramos	POR	WC22	3	1	0	0	4	Hat-trick vs Switzerland WC22 R16
14	Cody Gakpo	NED	WC22	3	0	0	0	3	Liverpool. Tournament specialist
15	Bukayo Saka	ENG	WC22	3	0	0	0	3	Arsenal. 14 int'l goals in 48 apps. FOX #21
16	Alexander Sorloth	NOR	—	—	—	—	—	NEW	Atletico. 13G La Liga + 6G CL. 4YC + 1RC = bonus pts!
17	Yan Diomande	CIV	—	—	—	—	—	NEW	RB Leipzig. 12G 8A in Bundesliga at age 19. Breakout star
18	Kenan Yildiz	TUR	—	—	—	—	—	NEW	Juventus. 10G 6A Serie A. Serie A Rising Star. 3 qualifying goals

Rank	Player	Country	WC Hist.	G	A	YC	RC	Pts	2025-26 Club Form / Notes
19	Lionel Messi	ARG	WC22	11	4	1	0	16	Record 6th WC at 38. Highest WC history score. Limited minutes likely
20	Cristiano Ronaldo	POR	WC22	2	1	0	0	3	Age 41. Scored in 5 consecutive WCs. Legacy pick

Midfielders (pick 5)

Rank	Player	Country	WC Hist.	G	A	YC	RC	Pts	2025-26 Club Form / Notes
1	Michael Olise	FRA	—	—	—	—	—	NEW	Bayern. 2025 Ballon d'Or winner . FOX #5 overall. Elite creativity
2	Bruno Fernandes	POR	WC22	2	3	1	0	6	Man Utd. 19 PL assists. Goals + assists + cards trifecta
3	Christoph Baumgartner	AUT	—	—	—	—	—	NEW	RB Leipzig. 13G 8A Bundesliga. Austrian POTY. Scores like a forward
4	Martin Odegaard	NOR	—	—	—	—	—	NEW	Arsenal captain. PL winner. Set-piece specialist. Feeds Haaland
5	Florian Wirtz	GER	—	—	—	—	—	NEW	Liverpool. Young playmaker. Germany's creative engine
6	Jude Bellingham	ENG	WC22	1	1	0	0	2	Real Madrid. La Liga POTY 2024. FOX #11
7	Hakan Calhanoglu	TUR	—	—	—	—	—	NEW	Inter. 9G 4A Serie A. Turkey captain. Pen + FK taker. 100+ caps
8	Arda Guler	TUR	—	—	—	—	—	NEW	Real Madrid. 6G 14A all comps. Led RM in chances created (111)
9	Scott McTominay	SCO	—	—	—	—	—	NEW	Napoli. 10G 3A Serie A as a MID. Physical = cards bonus
10	Kevin De Bruyne	BEL	WC22	1	2	0	0	3	Man City. Age 34 but elite passing
11	Pedri	ESP	—	—	—	—	—	NEW	Barcelona. 40 caps at 24. FOX #9
12	Neymar	BRA	WC22+14	6	2	1	0	9	INJURED — grade 2 calf strain. May miss opening games. High risk
13	James Rodriguez	COL	WC14	6	2	1	0	9	WC2014 Golden Boot. Age 34. Colombia talisman
14	Enzo Fernandez	ARG	WC22	1	1	1	0	3	Chelsea. WC22 Young Player Award. Cards + goals + assists
15	Adrien Rabiot	FRA	WC22	1	1	1	0	3	Ideal scoring profile: goals + assists + cards
16	Marcel Sabitzer	AUT	—	—	—	—	—	NEW	Dortmund. Austria's creative hub
17	Dani Olmo	ESP	WC22	1	1	0	0	2	Goals + assists in every tournament he plays
18	Frenkie de Jong	NED	WC22	1	1	1	0	3	Barcelona. Consistent all-rounder
19	Alexis Mac Allister	ARG	WC22	1	1	0	0	2	Liverpool. WC22 winner
20	Moises Caicedo	ECU	WC22	1	0	1	0	2	Chelsea. Physical = card bonus

Defenders (pick 5)

Rank	Player	Country	WC Hist.	G	A	YC	RC	Pts	2025-26 Club Form / Notes
1	Denzel Dumfries	NED	WC22	1	2	1	1	5	Inter. Highest-scoring DEF in WC22. Cards bonus king
2	Achraf Hakimi	MAR	WC22	0	1	0	0	1	PSG. FOX #7 overall (highest-ranked DEF). Elite pace
3	Theo Hernandez	FRA	WC22	1	2	1	0	4	AC Milan. Goals + assists + cards from LB
4	Nuno Mendes	POR	—	—	—	—	—	NEW	PSG. Top fantasy DEF pick. "Plays like a winger"
5	Joshua Kimmich	GER	WC22	0	0	1	0	1	Bayern. 2G 1A in qualifying. Attacking returns from DEF
6	Alphonso Davies	CAN	WC22	1	0	1	0	2	Bayern. FOX #25. "Canada's most important player"
7	David Alaba	AUT	—	—	—	—	—	NEW	Real Madrid captain. World-class LB/CB
8	Andrew Robertson	SCO	—	—	—	—	—	NEW	Liverpool. Elite attacking LB. Assist machine
9	Virgil van Dijk	NED	—	—	—	—	—	NEW	Liverpool. FOX #22. Aerial threat from set pieces
10	Nahuel Molina	ARG	WC22	1	1	0	0	2	Atletico. Goals + assists from RB
11	Ferdi Kadioglu	TUR	—	—	—	—	—	NEW	Brighton. Dynamic attacking wing-back
12	Kevin Danso	AUT	—	—	—	—	—	NEW	Tottenham. Aggressive CB = card magnet (bonus pts!)
13	Manuel Akanji	SUI	WC22	1	0	1	0	2	Man City. Goal-scoring CB + cards
14	Josko Gvardiol	CRO	WC22	1	0	0	0	1	Man City. Goal threat from CB at 24
15	Diogo Dalot	POR	WC22	0	2	0	0	2	Man Utd. 2 assists at WC22
16	Gonzalo Montiel	ARG	WC22	0	0	3	0	3	Atletico. 3 yellows = 3 pts. Cards specialist
17	Jules Kounde	FRA	WC22	0	0	1	0	1	Barcelona. 40+ apps/season. Consistent
18	Min-jae Kim	KOR	—	—	—	—	—	NEW	Bayern. "One of the great CBs of the tournament"
19	Piero Hincapie	ECU	—	—	—	—	—	NEW	Leverkusen. Young CB rising star
20	Julian Ryerson	NOR	—	—	—	—	—	NEW	Dortmund. Attacking RB. Norway's solid backline

Goalkeepers (pick 1)

Rank	Player	Country	Notes
1	Emiliano Martinez	ARG	WC22 Golden Glove. Penalty specialist. Argentina likely deep run

Rank	Player	Country	Notes
2	Mike Maignan	FRA	AC Milan. Top shot-stopper. France = clean sheet machine
3	Jordan Pickford	ENG	England conceded 0 goals in all of qualifying
4	Marc-Andre ter Stegen	GER	Barcelona. Elite distribution
5	Dominik Livakovic	CRO	WC22 penalty hero. Croatia defensive
6	Alisson	BRA	Liverpool. Best passing GK. Brazil should dominate group
7	Bart Verbruggen	NED	Brighton. Young, highly rated
8	Orjan Nyland	NOR	Sevilla. Norway well-organized under Solbakken

GK Note: Clean sheets (1pt each) are the main GK scorer. Prioritize keepers from strong defensive teams likely to go deep (France, England, Argentina). Historical GK points above only reflect cards — clean sheet data was unavailable.

Draft Strategy Cheat Sheet

Tip	Explanation
Cards = free points	YC/RC are +1 each. Physical players (Gyokeres 5YC, Sorloth 4YC+1RC, Dumfries, Montiel) are more valuable than in standard fantasy
Max 1 per country	Can't stack Argentina or France. Best combos: FRA forward + NOR mid, or ENG forward + FRA mid
Penalty takers	Haaland (NOR), Oyarzabal (ESP), Calhanoglu (TUR), Mbappe (FRA) — extra goal upside
New country sleepers	Norway, Sweden, Turkiye, Austria, Cote d'Ivoire have elite talent with no WC history to compare
Avoid	Neymar (injured), Perisic (37), Enner Valencia (36), Isak (injury-disrupted season)
Coach pick	France or Argentina for the 10pt winner bonus